KERALA

REBUILDING WAYANAD

By Jeemon Jacob

Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan has always had a knack of finding form when crisis is upon the state, especially in the face of natural disasters. The 2018 mega floods tested his abilities as captain of Kerala, followed by the Coronavirus outbreak in 2020. His steady hand then had much to do with him earning a second innings in 2021.

Now another challenge awaits—rehabilitation of the survivors of the Wayanad landslide that officially killed 359 people and led to the loss of two whole villages—Mundakkai and Chooralmala—in the hilly Western Ghats in July 2024. Kerala had requested a Rs 2,219 crore special package for Wayanad's rehabilitation in August, but after five months, the Union Government finally classified the landslides as a "disaster of severe nature for all practical purposes" and offered little else extra. The Centre's rationale was that Kerala has enough funds in its State Disaster Relief Fund (SDRF) allotment for 2024-25—some Rs 388 crore, out of which Rs 291.2 crore was the central share. The state also reported an SDRF balance of Rs 395 crore from previous years, New Delhi said, arguing that the corpus of nearly Rs 800 crore was enough to manage the relief efforts.

Kerala is now going ahead with the reconstruction process on its own, and plans to complete the projects before March 2026, when the state is due for assembly polls. Pinarayi's appeal for funds through the 'Stand with Wayanad' campaign had collected a healthy Rs 708.2 crore till January 6. The state revenue department has published the list of beneficiaries who are eligible for new houses and the government estimates the cost of reconstruction to be around Rs 1,100 crore. The affected region officially had some 2,007 housing units spread across three wards in Meppadi panchayat. Considering the hilly terrain, the state estimates the average cost of a 1,000 sq. ft housing unit to be around Rs 30 lakh.

"We will not compromise on the quality of houses," CM Pinarayi told INDIA TODAY. "An MoU has been signed with a reputed construction company, Uralungal Labour Contract Cooperative Society, and a website will be set up to give updates. Each sponsor will get a unique ID, so that they can monitor the progress."

The state says the cost was estimated by the Central Public Works Department (CPWD) but there is some confu-



SWEPT AWAY File picture of rescue workers with the body of a victim after the landslides in Mundakkai

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